

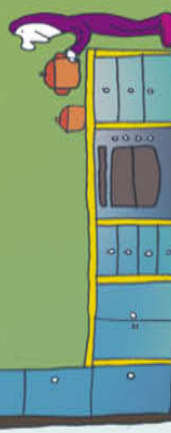
The Far West

The extreme west of Africa is watered by the Senegal and Gambia rivers and is mainly low-lying, with grasslands in the south and semidesert conditions towards the north.



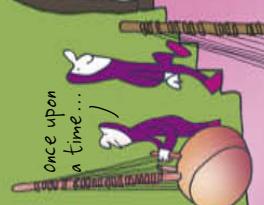
Cape Verde

Once a Portuguese colony, many of the towns of these offshore islands have colonial-style buildings.



Senegal

Local griots (tribal storytellers) relate stories of past events accompanied by the kora—a 21-stringed instrument with a soundbox made from a gourd.



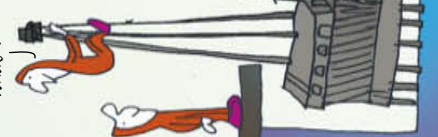
Did I miss the story?



Nigeria

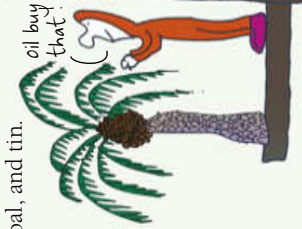
Africa's most populated nation and the 10th most populated country in the world, Nigeria is home to many diverse groups of peoples. Approximately 250 different ethnic groups live here, speaking numerous languages, although English—the former colonial language—is the only official language.

What?



Oil wealth

Nigeria is one of Africa's biggest producers of oil and also has vast reserves of natural gas as well as iron ore, bauxite, coal, and tin.



Benin

A mainly agricultural nation, Benin's people live off the land and catch fish in its rivers or off its narrow coastline.



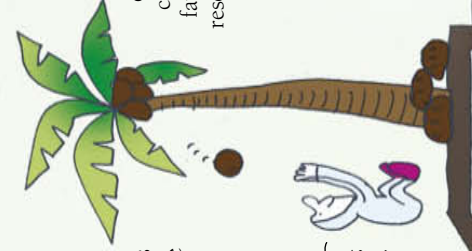
Togo

This long, thin country is self-sufficient in basic foodstuffs, growing corn, yams, rice, and cassava to eat, and cocoa, coffee, and cotton to export.



The Guinea Coast

Extending from Guinea-Bissau in the west to Cameroon and Equatorial Guinea in the east, the Guinea Coast is low-lying and wooded, with mangrove swamps along the shore. The origin of its name is not clear, but it is thought to come from Jenne—an important 8th-century trading kingdom.



Cleaning up your act?



Liberia

Founded in 1847 as a home for freed U.S.

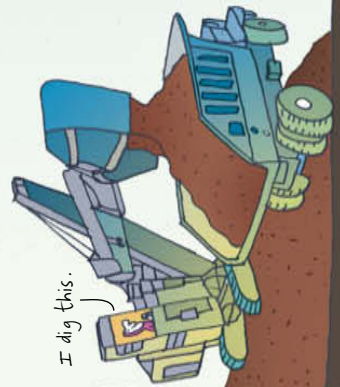


slaves returning to Africa, Liberia has plantations of rubber trees that are tapped for their latex—the sap that is used to make rubber.



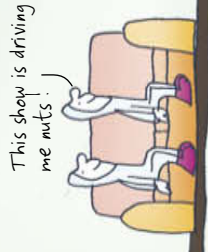
Sierra Leone

Rich in diamonds, Sierra Leone provides many of the gems used in engagement rings and other pieces of jewelry.



Guinea

More than 30 per cent of the world's bauxite—used to make aluminum—is mined in Guinea, as well as gold, diamonds, and iron ore.



Guinea-Bissau

Cashews, groundnuts, coconuts, and rice are the main crops grown by Guinea-Bissau's farmers, while its main natural resources are fish and timber.

The Ivory and Gold Coasts

These two stretches of the Guinea Coast were named by Europeans for the products they traded there. The region is tropical and fertile, allowing a wide range of crops to be grown.



Ivory Coast

The world's biggest producer of cocoa, the Ivory Coast also exports coffee and timber.



Ghana

Africa's second-biggest producer of gold, Ghana exports this precious metal along with diamonds, bauxite, and manganese.

Copycat building

The massive Roman Catholic basilica of Yamoussoukro is modeled on St. Peter's Basilica in Rome.

